

Who or what is a watcher?



Nebuchadnezzar recounts his dream to Daniel for interpretation.

Daniel 4:10-12

¹⁰ Thus were the visions of mine head in my bed; I saw, and behold a tree in the midst of the earth, and the height thereof was great.

¹¹ The tree grew, and was strong, and the height thereof reached unto heaven, and the sight thereof to the end of all the earth:

¹² The leaves thereof were fair, and the fruit thereof much, and in it was meat for all: the beasts of the field had shadow under it, and the fowls of the heaven dwelt in the boughs thereof, and all flesh was fed of it.

In [Daniel 4:10-17](#) when Nebuchadnezzar is recounting his dream to Daniel he uses some interesting language that we can learn a great deal from.

Daniel 4:13

I saw in the visions of my head upon my bed, and, behold, a watcher and an holy one came down from heaven;

At first glance, because both nouns (“*watcher*” & “*holy one*”) have their own determiner (“*a*” & “*an*”) combined with the conjunction “*and*” it appears that two different entities appeared in Nebuchadnezzar’s dream. And under normal English grammatical rules this would be the correct interpretation. If one of those nouns lacked a determiner (eg. “*a watcher and holy one*” or “*a great and mighty warrior*”) the interpretation would be that they are two words describing the same entity. Because of this, it might be very easy to miss an important detail in the context that follows this verse.

Daniel 4:13-16

¹³ I saw in the visions of my head upon my bed, and, behold, **a watcher and an holy one** came down from heaven;

¹⁴ **He cried aloud**, and said thus, Hew down the tree, and cut off his branches, shake off his leaves, and scatter his fruit: let the beasts get away from under it, and the fowls from his branches:

¹⁵ Nevertheless leave the stump of his roots in the earth, even with a band of iron and brass, in the tender grass of the field; and let it be wet with the dew of heaven, and let his portion be with the beasts in the grass of the earth:

¹⁶ Let his heart be changed from man's, and let a beast's heart be given unto him; and let seven times pass over him.

Verse 14 begins with the **singular** pronoun “*He*” and that is what should catch our attention. The last noun that that pronoun refers back to is “*an holy one*”. But wait, the previous sentence uses the conjunction “*and*” with “*holy one*” which joins the two nouns together as one. Thus, together with the context the “*he*” is the same as **both** “*a watcher and an holy one*”. This literary figure of speech is a real thing and it has a fancy name: it's called a “*hendiadys*” (hen-dia-dis). The term comes from the Greek *hen dia duoin*, which literally means “one through two”. As it turns out, we use these all the time in modern speech.

Example English hendiadys:

- “Nice and warm” instead of “nicely warm”.
- “Good and ready” instead of “completely ready”.
- “Sick and tired” instead of “exceedingly tired” or “weary”.
- “brimstone and fire” instead of “burning sulfur”.

Before we continue though, there is one more small detail that we need to understand. From **Daniel 2:4b** to **Daniel 7:28** was written in “*Syriack*” and not Hebrew like most of the old testament (**Ezra 4:8-6:18**, **7:12-26**, **Jeremiah 10:11** are also written in some form of what we would call “*Aramaic*”). The word behind *Syriack* is אַרְמִית / *’āramīy* which when translated means “the language of Aram” (the region known as Syria and Mesopotamia). In modern times we refer to this language as *Chaldee* / *Chaldaic* / *Chaldean* or *Aramaic*. So, why is that important? Because just like Hebrew and Greek, Aramaic is a highly inflected language. In highly inflected languages each word of a sentence is modified to convey tense, gender, **number**, and case and it also must grammatically agree with the subject. To form proper sentence in those languages the tense, gender, **number**, and case of **every word** in the sentence must agree.

For example, in Hebrew, if a sentence has two subjects performing an action, the verb takes on a unique plural form to agree with the plurality of those subjects. If there were only one subject, the same verb would be spelled differently. English is very different (weakly inflected) as we can see in the examples of “I ran.”, “He ran.”, and “We ran.” – they all use the exact same verb form “ran” even when the subject **number** (plurality) changes.

English was not always weakly inflected and has changed in four major stages over time:

1. **Old English** (450-1150AD)
 - Highly inflected, not recognizable as English to a modern reader (eg. “Our Father which art in heaven” is written as “Fæder ūser, þū þe eart on heofonum”).
2. **Middle English** (1150-1500AD)
 - Inflections dissolve and thousands of French words enter the language.
3. **Early Modern English** (1500-1700AD)
 - Pronunciation shifted wildly and the printing press standardized spelling. The KJB (known then only as “The Holy Bible”) and William Shakespeare’s writings use this form of the language.
4. **Modern English** (1700AD-Present)
 - The globally spoken, weakly inflected language we use today.

Now, because Aramaic is a highly inflected language we can take advantage of that and look at the verbs, for example, to further confirm that the *watcher* and *holy one* in [Daniel 4:13](#) are indeed both the same entity - exactly as the singular pronoun “*He*” in [Daniel 4:14](#) implies (because in proper Aramaic grammar the verbs **must** agree in tense, gender, **number**, and case with the subject).

Later on in the chapter Daniel is interpreting Nebuchadnezzar’s dream to him and he refers to the watcher in the following way:

Daniel 4:23

And whereas the king saw a watcher and an holy one coming down from heaven, and saying, Hew the tree down, and destroy it; yet leave the stump of the roots thereof in the earth, even with a band of iron and brass, in the tender grass of the field; and let it be wet with the dew of heaven, and let his portion be with the beasts of the field, till seven times pass over him;

The verb “saying” in [Daniel 4:23](#) is classified by Strongs as H560 אָמַר / 'āmar and the dictionary form just so happens to match the exact form used in the Masoretic Text. If you weren’t already aware, the dictionary form more often than not **does not** match the exact form used in the text. For an in depth study on that topic see the article at the following URL: <https://cheerful-wmcdannell.wordpress.com/2026/02/17/the-dangers-of-relying-on-strongs-concordance-for-hebrew-greek-studies/>.

The actual words used in the 1524 Bomberg MT are:

“coming down from heaven, and saying”
נִחַת מִן־שָׁמַיָא וְאָמַר

Remember that Hebrew “square script” (Ktav Ashuri) / Aramaic is a RTL (right-to-left) language and so the “word” we are looking for is:

“and saying”
וְאָמַר

The prefix וְ is what is called a *proclitic particle* and it represents the English word “and”. If we strip away the “and” we are left with אָמַר which, as you can easily see, is the exact same **singular** masculine participle. Now that we’ve firmly established a relationship between a “*watcher*” and some other noun (“*holy one*”) we can then use that to define what exactly is a watcher in addition to what the name itself implies.

“*holy one*” ([Daniel 4:13,17,23](#)) is classified by Strongs as H6922 which of course is an Aramaic word but it corresponds to the Hebrew H6918. H6922 is very telling on it’s own in that it shows up in the following verses as the following English words:

Daniel 7:18	But the saints
Daniel 7:21	the saints
Daniel 7:22	to the saints
Daniel 7:25	the saints
Daniel 7:27	of the saints

It also shows up elsewhere as “*and an holy one*”, “*of the holy*”, and “*of the holy ones*” but when searching for a definition we can’t necessarily use the word itself.

We don't even need to look at where H6918 shows up but if you are curious it appears as the word "saint/saints" in 12 out of the 116 times it appears in the Bible ([Deu 33:3](#), [Job 5:1,15:15](#), [Psa 16:3,34:9](#), [89:5,7](#), [106:16](#), [Dan 8:13](#) [the first two but not the third which is italicized], [Hos 11:12](#), [Zec 14:5](#)).

So, who are these watchers? The Bible couldn't be any more clear. It's exactly the same entity that John encountered in

Revelation 19:9-10
⁹ And he saith unto me, Write, Blessed are they which are called unto the marriage supper of the Lamb. And he saith unto me, These are the true sayings of God.
¹⁰ And I fell at his feet to worship him. And he said unto me, See thou do it not: I am thy fellowservant, and of thy brethren that have the testimony of Jesus: worship God: for the testimony of Jesus is the spirit of prophecy.

Who **exactly** is the "he" in verse 9? It's one of the seven angels from [Revelation 17:1](#) that was speaking to John.

Revelation 17:1	One of the seven angels which had the seven vials
Revelation 17:3	So he carried me away in the spirit
Revelation 17:7	And the angel said unto me
Revelation 17:15	And he saith unto me
Revelation 18	John sees <i>another</i> angel, hears <i>another</i> voice from heaven, sees <i>another</i> mighty angel cast a stone into the sea
Revelation 19:9	And he saith unto me

And when we combine what we learned about the "*holy ones*" with the definition of the Hebrew word H5782 that the Aramaic H5894 "watcher" corresponds to in [Daniel 4:13](#) it becomes even more clear:

H5782
עוּר 'ûwr, oor; a primitive root (rather identical with through the idea of opening the eyes); **to wake** (literally or figuratively):—(a-) wake(-n, up), lift up (self), × master, raise (up), stir up (self).
Translated elsewhere as: awake, stir up, lifted up, raise, raised up, waked, wake up, waketh, stirred up, stirreth up, etc.

And so when it says "*a watcher and an holy one*" we can think of it as "a raised up saint" or "an awakened saint".

In other words, these watchers are humans that died in Christ (saints) and moved on to glory and were and are serving God as we can see in both the old ([Daniel 4:13,17,23](#)) and the new testament ([Revelation 19:10](#)).